

Passages - The Immoralist

Knowing how to free oneself is nothing; the difficult thing is knowing how to live with that freedom.

I loved friendship more than the friends themselves I was truly devoted to them, but out of a sense of my own nobility;

I cherished all my finer feelings. After all, I knew my friends as little as I knew myself. It never occurred to me that I could lead a different life, that there was a different way to live.

I didn't love life enough to feel sorry for myself, but the ugliness of this place distressed me.

Any heightened sensitivity can be a source of pleasure or pain, depending on the strength or weakness of one's constitution. Everything that was painful to me then is now a delight.

For me history now had that same static quality that had terrified me in the night-time shadows of the little courtyard in Biskra: the immobility of death.

As with anything where one has to overcome an initial revulsion, I began actually to enjoy this dissimulation. I would prolong it, as if to give my new, unknown faculties a chance to play.

And I moved forward each day towards a richer, fuller life and a more delicious happiness.

So much does the expectation and the surprise of love add to the delicious pleasure of the experience - great love

needs only a single night to express itself, and my memory insists on recalling that one night alone. It was a single moment which entwined both our souls in its laughter . . . But I believe that love reaches a certain pitch once and once only, which the soul ever after seeks in vain to surpass; that in striving to resurrect that happiness, it actually wears it out; that nothing is more fatal to happiness than the memory of happiness.

The finest works of mankind are universally concerned with suffering. How would one tell a story about happiness? One can only tell of the origins of happiness and its destruction.

I would come home drunk on fresh air, giddy with the speed of the gallop, my limbs somewhat stiff with a delicious tiredness, my soul full of health, appetite and freshness.

I hate resting. Possessions encourage this; when one feels secure one falls asleep. I love life enough to prefer to live it awake. So within all this wealth I preserve a sense of precariousness with which I aggravate, or at least intensify, my life.

'If only all these people here could see the sense of that. But most of them believe the only good comes from restraint; their pleasure is counterfeit. People don't want to be like themselves. They all choose a model to imitate, or if they don't choose a model themselves, they accept one ready-made. Yet I believe there are other things to be read in a man. No one dares. No one dares turn the page. The law of imitation - I call it the law of fear.

They fear finding themselves alone, so they don't find themselves at all. I detest

this moral agoraphobia, it is the worst form of cowardice.

He who invents must do so alone. But who here is trying to invent?

The things one feels are different about oneself are the things that are rare, that give each person his value - and these are the things they try to repress. They imitate, and they make out they love life!

The future can strip the present of its charm more than the present does to the past.

'I have also tailored my happiness to fit,' I cried out. 'But I have grown, and now my happiness is too tight, sometimes it almost strangles me...

'I don't wish to remember,' he replied. 'It would be like forestalling the future and allowing the past to encroach upon me. I create each hour anew only by completely forgetting the past. I am never content simply to have been happy. I don't believe in dead things.

For me, being no more is the same as never having been.'

The love that Marceline gave me, the love that she symbolized for me, was like rest for a man who isn't tired. But as I sensed how exhausted she was, and how much she needed my love, I lavished it on her, pretending that it sprang from my own need. I couldn't bear to see her suffering; I loved her in order to cure her.

Oh, if only I could clear my mind of this insufferable logic!... I feel there is nothing in me that is not noble.